

Fasting Deals With Your Unbelief

We are going to study most of the aspects of fasting, and even more than that, exactly what it does.

Lately, many people have been coming to me asking about strenuous jobs, easy jobs, work habits, and long fasts. I would not recommend a long fast with a strenuous job unless it became supernatural.

I remember a man in the mill where I worked. He was a pastor, and he loaded boxcars. He got so excited about miracles and the testimonies of men who fasted that he went on a fast while loading boxcars. He fasted thirty days. He was skinny when he started, and by the end he looked like a skeleton with skin stretched over it.

God visited him. The first thing God dealt with was what had been stopping him overall, and it had to do with faithfulness to God, the church he belonged to, and several other things. Nobody short of God could have convinced him. I could not. I was independent holiness, and he believed his church was the church and the bride. We talked many hours, but when he fasted, God was able to put something to death, and he accepted it.

There are different facets of fasting to understand. Some jobs would not allow you to do a forty-day fast unless it became supernatural. But the main thing is this: whether it is a long fast or series fasting, both can end up in the same place.

Series fasting might be two or three days on, two or three days off, then two or three days on again. You can maintain your strength with it. The good news is that a forty-day fast and a series of shorter fasts can both arrive at the same signpost.

One reason fasting is discouraged by some prominent teachers is that they do not like it. Some of them had an experience themselves, or saw somebody else have an experience, and that gave them enough justification to pull back. Some say, "I have never had to fast over three days in my life." Thank God for their operation. If that was enough for them, thank God.

But some went ahead and made that a doctrine for everybody else. I see too much lacking to stop there. I have millions of years to face, and my desire is to fulfill what He has called me to do.

I want a testimony like Paul:

I have fought a good fight, I have finished my course, I have kept the faith.

Paul called himself "Paul the aged." He wanted his coat and parchments. He was imprisoned again and ready to be offered. He had one offering left: a body that bore the marks of Jesus, after countless imprisonments and chains. They took him out and beheaded him.

However you think Paul left this earth, I can tell you this: it is not the way he entered heaven.

I am hungry to know Him more than I am hungry for food.

When do I fast? I fast when He leads me into it. But there are also times when the hunger inside outweighs the hunger outside, and I cannot pick the spoon up anymore.

Series fasting can be just as effective as a long fast. A forty-day fast is sometimes called the prophet's fast, but one reason people discourage longer fasts is that they have seen people get into them and get messed up. Some have even lost their health because they did not follow guidelines.

Another reason people teach against fasting is that they do not understand grace. You could not be any freer than what God has deposited in you by grace in the new nature. Fasting is not moving God. He is not the one stuck. He never has been, and He never will be.

He that spared not his own Son... how shall he not with him also freely give us all things?

Fasting enforces a position He has already given you.

Sometimes He will call you on a fast, especially if you are an intercessor and He lays a troubled area on you. You give everything you can to Him to change it. You pray, groan, fall in, and God needs a little more from you. So He kicks you into a fast.

Whatever is between you and the standing He gave you, whether it concerns revival, a lost person, or a horrible situation that needs to turn, fasting can move it out of your way. Then God comes.

We made the mistake of thinking our fasting moved God. It did not move Him. It lined us up to receive what He had already done.

When a person jumps into a long fast, he may be disappointed afterward if he thinks the fast itself is supposed to produce lightning, angels, power, and everybody falling down when he passes by.

God does everything He can in the fast. He does a great deal of good. But if you do not die enough in that fast, if He is not able to put to death enough of what is between you and Him and what you expect to happen, then you come out asking, "Where is it? Where is the lightning? Where is Jesus?"

I was disappointed after my first or second long fast because all God did was pick on me. He showed me my faults and magnified them so big that even I could not miss them.

After one of those longer fasts, I ran into me. I was locked up with a person I hated: me. God got me under a magnifying glass, and I did not like it. It hurt.

When I came out, I did not understand it. I tried to shake it off. I wanted to get back into meetings where His glory came. But where I had arrived in that fast, by the time I had set to break it, the only place He had gotten to in me was to reveal and begin putting to death what was between me and Him.

That was accomplished in the next fast, not that one.

I came out afraid. I felt lost and bad. I walked into services and it seemed like less power was operating. In those days we judged each other by how many people fell down. If I wanted people to fall under the power, I almost had to give them a little shove.

If all your eggs are in one basket, thinking one fast is it, and it is not it, you can get discouraged. That first fast may just get the rich topsoil off and get you down to the stones. The next one may get to the stones.

I have started a forty-day fast at least thirty times. In my early days, I did not think I would ever make it. I would start it and break it. Finally my wife said, "You are never going to do it."

When I finally did, she was overseas somewhere. We had an agreement that I would not break it unless we talked to each other. I tried to get hold of her and could not. I was dying, but I was out of contact, so I had to go on.

God was trying to get something over to me, and I had to be pretty dead. My big mouth kept saying, "I will not stop until I have this." What I wanted was no easy thing: not much, just Tulsa saved, and the rest of the world could come here and get it if they wanted.

Halfway through one fast, a peace came that birthed the series *Peace: The Aggressive Weapon of God*. I had never experienced anything quite like that.

As He taught me more and more, I found out my fasting did not move God. It moved me into position to receive from Him. Once I found that out, I could not put all my eggs in one basket. Maybe one forty-day fast was not all it would take. Maybe I would have to return another day.

That is why series fasting, short fasts done for seasons, can be just as effective. Eventually both kinds of fasting take you to the same place. It is not your personal sacrifice of not eating. It is what you are giving yourself to and how it enforces the position of grace Jesus has given you by taking the ceiling of the flesh off and letting the spirit come forward.

Imagine a group of people with one purpose: to serve Him and receive an outpouring. You cannot receive an outpouring in Tulsa without receiving an outpouring in your personal life too. It will not just be here. You will carry a torch.

Go to Matthew 17. We will return to this chapter in the future, but for now we will extract the foundation.

Father, I am hungry for the food that does not perish. I am hungrier than my outer man. Explain these principles to us like never before. We yield ourselves to You. We pray for every person who is indifferent, every person who serves themselves and does not understand the glory and the things You have for us. Deal with each of us where we are. I get to offer the information; You bring the increase. There is no condemnation. Teach us, Jesus. As Your children, we are careful to give You all the praise, honor, and glory.

Matthew 17:14 says:

And when they were come to the multitude, there came to him a certain man, kneeling down to him...

Peter, James, and John had been up on the Mount of Transfiguration with Jesus. When they came down, they found a crowd around the nine disciples left behind. Those disciples had been casting out devils, but they had run into one that held its ground. No matter what they said or did, it would not come out.

The man said:

Lord, have mercy on my son: for he is lunatick, and sore vexed...

The devil often threw him into fire and water to destroy him.

Then:

I brought him to thy disciples, and they could not cure him.

Jesus answered:

O faithless and perverse generation, how long shall I be with you? how long shall I suffer you? bring him hither to me.

You have to understand that they were between covenants. Jesus was fulfilling the law by becoming the last sacrifice, but He was preaching and administering the principles of the new covenant.

He had given His disciples power over unclean spirits. He had put His mantle upon them, and it worked. When they returned from casting out devils, healing the sick, and raising the dead, they were excited. "Even the devils are subject unto us through Thy name."

Jesus said, in effect, "I am glad you are glad devils are subject to you, but rejoice rather that your names are written in heaven." He was there to pay the price for that.

But then they ran into this one. Jesus said, "How long am I going to have to do this for you? What I gave you should have been enough."

Then He rebuked the devil, and the child was cured from that hour.

The disciples came to Jesus privately and asked:

Why could not we cast him out?

They did exactly what I would have done. I would not have yelled over the crowd, "Why could we not cast it out?" I would not need that kind of humiliation in my ministry. Privately, they asked Him the question.

Jesus said:

Because of your unbelief.

As a faith man, I would not have wanted it worded that way. "Unbelief" is not in my vocabulary. Could we say, "I am developing my faith"? But Jesus said, "You asked why it would not come out. I am telling you: because of your unbelief."

Fasting does not move the devil, and it does not move God. It has something to do with your unbelief.

The question is: what does not eating have to do with unbelief?

Jesus continued:

If ye have faith as a grain of mustard seed, ye shall say unto this mountain, Remove hence to yonder place; and it shall remove; and nothing shall be impossible unto you.

He is saying that if you ever learn to deal with this particular kind of unbelief, nothing shall be impossible to you.

Then verse 21 says:

Howbeit this kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting.

Most preachers have linked "this kind" to a certain class of devil. They say, "This kind of demon comes out only by prayer and fasting." Then someone says, "I do not have a deliverance ministry, so I do not need to fast."

That is one way to excuse yourself from fasting.

But Jesus had just said the reason the devil would not come out was unbelief. If the disciples had known they had that unbelief, why would they have asked Jesus why the demon did not come out?

We are talking about the subtlest, most deceptive kind of unbelief, the kind that puts a ceiling on your life. You can run around under that ceiling the rest of your life and fulfill only what you fulfill.

How many times have I approached a child in a wheelchair and known I could not blame that child for unbelief? Yet they were imprisoned in their body.

Do you understand how free a child's spirit is? I cannot imagine a child being imprisoned in their own body. Most churches have accepted the ceiling. They assign those kinds of miracles to special ministries.

Miracles are not only for the evangelist. They are for the benefit of the local church, which is supposed to be a stronghold behind enemy lines, taking the city where God left it.

I have laid hands on children like that with every fiber of my being. I milked myself for faith. I turned myself inside out. If I knew how to have any more faith, I would have had it. I called on every cell and fiber of my body to yield faith. And they did not get out.

If Jesus walked in with His glorified body, went over, got the child out, and then came back to me, I would ask, "With every fiber of my being, I believed for that child. Why did the child not get up when I prayed?"

Do you think Jesus would give me any other answer than He gave them? He would look me in the eye and say, "Son, because of your unbelief."

I might say, "But Jesus, I milked every fiber of my being."

Nevertheless, like His disciples, I asked why it did not come out, and He would answer the same way.

One thing I love about Jesus is that He never outlines a problem without giving the answer. The answer had to lie within what He gave them.

Jesus said:

Howbeit this kind goeth not out but by prayer and fasting.

Obviously, the prayer He is talking about was not the prayer they uttered over the demon-possessed child, because that prayer already failed. Could He be talking about a lifestyle?

Early in ministry, while still in my twenties and working at the mill, I was ministering to a little congregation because the pastor had been in a wreck. I would go to the church and pray for the message.

One day the Lord said to me, "Do you want to see the people begin to get healed? As it is, you are honorable because you will stay with them a long time, praying and praying into the night. Then the next one will come along, and you will pray and pray until either you give up or they get it."

Not many got it.

He said, "Do you not know that you can go into your closet and get to know Me? Then you do not have to spend all night with them. You already did that with Me."

Prayer builds faith. I understand what prayer has to do with unbelief. You pray, speak the Word, fellowship with God, pray in tongues, and build yourself up on your most holy faith. You release authority.

But I did not understand what fasting had to do with unbelief. I knew fasting did not move God. Isaiah 58 says the fast they chose was to smite with the fist of wickedness, that their voice might be heard on high. But the fast He chooses is not so your voice can be heard on high; it is so you can hear Him down low.

Romans 8:10 says:

And if Christ be in you, the body is dead because of sin; but the Spirit is life because of righteousness.

The word "Spirit" there should be your human spirit. Your spirit has come alive because of the righteousness it has been made through the nature of Christ quickened together with you.

You and I understand the positional truth of our spirit: quickened together with Him, seated with Him in heavenly places, above and not beneath. But we know very little about the positional truth declared over our flesh, which is dead.

Not dead as in the grave and you in heaven, but dead concerning its ability to reign over your spirit. It does not have that ability. We think it does, but it does not.

When you were born again, your spirit was seated with Him in heavenly places. But He also provided a positional truth for your body. As far as its ability to reign over your spirit is concerned, He called it dead.

That is why fasting did Mahatma Gandhi no spiritual good. He had no positional truth to enforce in his body because he had no new nature to enforce it. He got hungry and deceived.

On my way back from Brazil, I sat next to two women who had been at a world religions gathering where the Dalai Lama spoke. I could tell by how they were dressed that we were in for a ride.

They asked what I did. I said I was coming back from a preachers' conference where I taught preachers the next step in walking in the power of God. I told them about surrendering to Jesus, about miracles, and about India where God moved and started saving Hindus.

The Holy Spirit said inside me, "If they had a new nature, they would not be running around looking for their consciousness to be cleansed from sin."

Satan is hideous. He gets people spiritually dead, then tells them they need to live in love and good works toward their fellow man. Then, because they cannot do it, he tells them maybe in two or three hundred lifetimes they will get there.

When they close their eyes the last time, what a shock.

They can fast all they want, but it will not do any good because their spirits have not been born again. There is no positional truth for the body, declared dead, to enforce.

This is what fasting does for the believer: it executes with force the positional truth that your body has been declared dead.

Fasting keeps driving the flesh down. If the flesh has been ceilinging your walk in the Spirit, fasting and prayer enforce the position that your body has been declared dead.

Your flesh says, "Fast? Fast? What am I going to do?" It bounces, fights, and complains. But something is happening. Eventually, victory comes. Your spirit ceilings your flesh, and what God promised starts coming to pass.

Then you think, "I really moved God."

No, my friend. He is not the one stuck. You moved yourself out from under whatever it was by executing the positional truth that your flesh has been declared dead.

That is why, when you have put all your eggs in the forty-day basket and it does not finish the job, do not stop. Go into series fasting. Eventually, your spirit's position will come forward and somebody will get a prayer answered.

I used to negotiate with my flesh. Every fast I broke prematurely, I would say, "Not only will I pray, I will rise at dawn. I will add another hour." Then I would break the fast and tell my wife, "He told me to break it and just pray."

Before long, the flesh had taken both away from me.

There is a forty-day fast, the fast God chose for Jesus, and we will get into that. But what God is after is the change. That is why series fasting is just as powerful. You may have to keep going, but eventually the flesh will fall below.

Your flesh will want to negotiate: "I will let you pray." But do not let it get away with it.

You can hurt yourself if you are not wise. You are not meant to stuff a whole turkey down your throat five days into a fast. Your body will have trouble with it.

With fasting, there are certain things you need to do going in and coming out. Isaiah 58 says your health will spring forth speedily, but there are things you have to adhere to.

Be kind to yourself. Begin with short fasts. Talk to people who know. Talk to some of the old fasters around here so you do not hurt yourself going in and out. With a three-day fast, there is not as much to be concerned about. The first day coming out, just be easy on yourself. You should be eating salad anyway.

Visions of grandeur may dance in your head about crucifying unbelief, but wait until you are three or four days in. Then you may say, "What have I done? Why did I set ten days? I am dying here."

The long hours of nothing but you, your flesh, and the gnawing in your belly will talk to you. Your friends will eat right in front of you and say, "Oh, I am sorry. You are fasting."

You will overcome all of it.

Hallelujah.